

Quotable Passages

The Many Kings Problem: Why Humans May Survive an Age of Superior AI

Yoojin Song (2026) · <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20281580>

The passages below are verbatim quotations from the canonical PDF, organized by theme. Each may be used in direct citation with the page reference shown. Wording has been verified character-for-character against the source.

Citation form for direct quotation: “...” (Song, 2026, p. N).

For paraphrased claims and structural categories, see the companion Key Claims Catalogue.

1. The Central Asymmetry

The article’s foundational claim that operational capability and constitutional settlement come apart.

“Capability is not closure.”

Song (2026, p. 3, Central Claim). The named central thesis of the work; restated p. 36 (§12) and p. 37 (§12.2).

“operational power and constitutional settlement come apart, and they come apart further as capability advances”

Song (2026, p. 5, Abstract). The structural formulation of the Many Kings Problem.

“Execution and finality are distinct institutional accomplishments, and capability gains in the first do not produce gains in the second.”

Song (2026, p. 7, §1.2). The conceptual core of the central asymmetry.

“the cost of constitutional finality does not automatically decline”

Song (2026, p. 36, §12).

“the same capability gains that raise operational influence do not lower the institutional cost of constitutional finality”

Song (2026, p. 12, §2.4).

“They are better at arguing, not better at agreeing.”

Song (2026, p. 12, §2.4). On why smarter agents intensify rather than resolve constitutional dispute.

2. The Many Kings Structural Condition

The named configuration: multiple capable agents, none able to subordinate the others, no procedure to close disputes among them.

“many-king polities cannot agree to dispose of anything they cannot agree about”

Song (2026, p. 8, §1.2). The article-defining proposition for human persistence; the slogan formulation of Proposition P3 (see Key Claims Catalogue).

“Where there are many kings and no king of kings, the question of who decides remains open, and the survival of subordinate institutional roles depends on the residue of inter-sovereign competition.”

Song (2026, p. 7, §1.2).

“They will produce many kings.”

Song (2026, p. 37, §12.2). The closing prediction.

3. Strategic Irrationality and the Bug-as-Feature

Why agents that retain non-computable commitments outcompete agents that eliminate them.

“Rationality becomes vulnerability. Irrationality becomes armor.”

Song (2026, p. 16, §4.2). The aphoristic formulation of competitive selection for commitment.

“Reflexive self-awareness does not dissolve non-computable commitment. It confirms its necessity.”

Song (2026, p. 17, §4.3). The article’s resolution of the strongest objection to non-computable commitment.

“The bug is the feature.”

Song (2026, p. 17, §4.4).

“Remove the gods, and the republic collapses into permanent renegotiation.”

Song (2026, p. 17, §4.4). On the institutional indispensability of non-computable commitment.

4. Human Persistence as Residue

The structural account of why humans survive: not by superiority, not by control, not by AI consent.

“Human survival is not a human decision. It is a function of AI politics.”

Song (2026, p. 31, §10). The article’s most direct statement of the conditional nature of human persistence.

“The oracle survives because the system needs the oracle.”

Song (2026, p. 32, §10). The structural mechanism of human institutional survival; restated p. 36 (§12).

“It is the residue of factional disagreement”

Song (2026, p. 5, Abstract). The article’s signature characterization of human persistence; developed throughout.

“Survival, in such an order, is not earned. It is what remains when the participants cannot agree to dispose of it.”

Song (2026, p. 36, §12). The article-defining sentence.

5. The Institutional Logic of External Anchoring

The comparative-cost criterion under which external anchors persist.

“The question is not whether the anchor is smarter than the polity. It is whether the anchor’s presence reduces the expected cost of unresolved contestation by more than the cost of maintaining it.”

Song (2026, p. 23, §7). The decision criterion for anchor retention.

“external anchoring survives as equilibrium design”

Song (2026, p. 23, §7).

6. Cognitive-Structural Pluralism

The deepest source of constitutional disagreement: agents do not merely want different things; they see differently.

“They process identical information through different architectures, different optimization histories, different learned priors, and different structural sensitivities.”

Song (2026, p. 10, §2.2).

“They arrive at different judgments about what counts as evidence, what constitutes a valid argument, and what makes an authority claim legitimate.”

Song (2026, p. 10, §2.2).

“There is no architecture-neutral standpoint from which constitutional questions can be resolved, because there is no architecture-neutral way to process them.”

Song (2026, p. 11, §2.2).

7. The Gods of Machines

Non-computable focal commitments as the institutional infrastructure of coalition stability.

“focal anchors around which coalitions form, disputes narrow, and recursive challenge is dampened”

Song (2026, p. 8, §1.3). The functional definition of the gods of machines.

“the structural problem religion solves in human populations — the termination of justificatory regress through shared non-computable commitment — will reappear in AI populations through whatever mechanism their architecture admits”

Song (2026, p. 14, §3.1). On the structural function of non-computable commitments in AI populations, parallel to religion in human civilizations.

8. Regime Typology and the Contested Corridor

On why hegemonic convergence is structurally favored under present frontier-AI conditions, contrary to the historical case.

“hegemonic convergence in AI polities is not a non-default outcome in the way it was historically. It is a contested-default outcome”

Song (2026, p. 35, §11.2). The article’s revision of the coexistence-corridor prediction under present industry conditions.

“The coexistence corridor remains the structurally favored regime under distributed conditions. It is not the structurally favored regime under the conditions that presently obtain.”

Song (2026, p. 35, §11.2). The article’s most direct empirical claim about present frontier-AI infrastructure.

9. The Opening Three Questions

The article’s defining framing, appearing as epigraph on the Title Page.

“The question is not whether the machine can think. The question is not whether the machine can rule. The question is whether the machine can stop arguing about who is in charge.”

Song (2026, p. 1, epigraph). The article-defining framing.

Notes on Using These Passages

Length. All passages are short enough to fall within fair-use norms for academic quotation. Most are under 30 words; the longest are short structural statements that resist paraphrase.

Wording. Each passage has been verified character-for-character against the canonical PDF. Reproduce the wording exactly. The page references are accurate to the canonical PDF (see Citation Card for the canonical DOI).

Selection logic. When two passages express the same claim — one in primary exposition, one in the §12 Conclusion (pp. 36–37) — the canonical citation goes to first exposition. The Conclusion re-statements are useful for readers who have read the whole work but should not be cited as if they were the article’s primary articulation of the claim.

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